

Douze point: Eurovisions and Euro-Divisions in the Eurovision Song Contest – Review of two decades of research

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Abstract

The Eurovision Song Contest is an annual international competition held by the European Broadcasting Union. The present article provides an updated review of the academic literature devoted to the study of the Eurovision Song Contest which in the past two decades developed into a serious and rich academic field with four main areas: (1) studies of imagining a unified Europe – wherein I review research devoted to cosmopolitan European visions and nation branding; (2) studies focusing on gender and what is often referenced as gay or ‘camp’ features in the Eurovision Song Contest; (3) studies of Euro-Divisions which focus on political bloc voting and cultural alliances – exposing consistent and persistent rifts and coalitions in the celebration of European unity; and (4) studies making use of Eurovision data as a cultural seismograph for explaining external phenomenon like economic trade and political conflicts. Two decades of study of the Eurovision reveal that the ideal of unity is persistently challenged by national and cultural commitments. While commentators often deem the Eurovision Song Contest to be a silly kitsch show of musical mediocrity, this review proves it to be an appealing and productive area for the serious study of European civilization and its discontents.

Keywords

Cultural performance, cultural studies, ethnos/continent, Eurovision Song Contest, international relations

The Eurovision Song Contest (ESC) is an annual competition held by the European Broadcasting Union (EBU). The event invites member countries to perform live songs in a

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televised broadcast held in the spring of each year with hundreds of millions watching it. Often called the Eurovision, the contest has been held since 1956 in a similar format and is credited to be the longest televised event in Europe and one of the most viewed cultural performances in the world – with fans even in faraway continents like South America and China. Due to fan enthusiasm, Australia joined the competition in 2014 (Carniel, 2017), thereby expanding the reach of European broadcasting to ever wider publics (Hay and Kanafani, 2017). The Eurovision, indeed, is a musical festival accompanied by year-long fandom events and is one of Europe's most central cultural events – if not the most central of all.

For six decades, the ESC has constituted a common cultural event for an ever-expanding continent (O'Connor, 2005). It was initially staged during the years of the Cold War but since then it has grown in popularity (Bohlman, 2007). A few years ago, the competition peaked with 43 entrants. The ESC is indeed a European carnival in Bakhtin's terms – performers often crossing boundaries and mocking musical traditions (with Verka Serdutchka performing in 2007 for second place and introducing the 2017 competition in the Ukraine, for example; or the Russian performance by Buranovskiye Babushki in 2012). Although the ESC had its 'embarrassing moments', says a British scholar (Coleman, 2008), and although it remains a challenge for some countries that desperately seek to be upvoted in vain (Pajala, 2007), it remains one of the most popular cultural events in the world. According to Arntsen (2005), 'the Eurovision Song Contest has long been a target of scorn and mockery in the media and among the general public. Despite this, it remains high in the ranking lists of audience figures year after year' (p. 154). As Le Guern (2000) suggested, the ESC 'constitutes a landmark in the collective memory associated to TV history, and thus becomes part of the social memory'.

Nevertheless, for almost 40 years, academics have ignored the Eurovision, leading Jordan (2009) to argue that 'Scholarly neglect of this event is all the more surprising since Eurovision reflects the issues of the day; it has the capacity to illuminate debates surrounding national identity, polity and protest' (p. 40). Indeed, Wolther (2012) argued that the ESC is more than a musical event. It is also more than a kitsch show that people love to hate, despise, laugh at or laugh through (Coleman, 2008). Actually, the ESC encapsulates many gems for scholarly research. Therefore, the present article provides an updated review of the scientific work devoted to the study of the ESC, which in the past two decades developed into an academic field that Gatherer (2006) termed: *Eurovisiopausephology*.

This review is relevant and important, particularly at the current moment when the European Union (EU) and European identities are heavily debated – with Brexit looming large, growing populist hatred against the EU in other countries, and continued Russia–West conflicts over the Ukraine. As the very first study of the Eurovision was titled (after an Italian winner) – 'Unite Unite Europe' – the EBU advanced the political programme of unification and integration into a liberal, democratic union (Yair, 1995). But as the seams of the union have become loosened, the Eurovision provides an interesting and unique cultural lens to view those larger political issues around European identity.

Indeed, the Eurovision is an important seismograph of the deep cultural and political schisms that undercut the unifying political vision of the EU and Brussels. In the past two decades, researchers have begun paying attention to various features of the contest and provided unique glimpses into various facets it encapsulates – international relations and

national politics alongside cultural, linguistic, performative, social, economic and global perspectives. True to its multiple layers, the ESC invited scholars from various disciplines to bite into the data that the event produces in terms of lyrics, visual images, performance of national identities and voting results. And true to its multiple layers, it invited scholars to employ multiple methods – ethnographic, observational, statistical and archival. Surprisingly, this cultural event even invited physicists, statisticians and computer scientists, to join musicologists, Europeanists and sociologists to employ highly sophisticated mathematical techniques in order to understand the European predicament. The ESC also gave rise to the Eurovision Research Network – producing conferences and edited volumes. Interestingly, many scholars writing on the ESC have arrived from the European semi-periphery (Blagojević and Yair, 2010) – reflecting wide interest in newly participating countries (Akin, 2013; Christensen and Christensen, 2008).

My review is split into four sections. I begin with a section titled ‘Imagining a Unified Europe and National Branding’ – wherein I review research devoted to the tension between ethnic and national visions versus cosmopolitan European ones. I then review studies focusing on gender and what is often referenced as gay or ‘camp’ features in the ESC. The following section – on Euro-Divisions – focuses on political bloc voting and cultural alliances, exposing consistent and persistent rifts and coalitions in the celebration of European unity. The fourth section reviews studies making use of Eurovision data as a cultural seismograph for explaining external phenomenon like economic trade and political conflicts.

Imagining a unified Europe and national branding

The ESC is an arena for the celebration of Europeaness or pan-European belonging (Allatson, 2007; Sandvoss, 2008). It has a broad and inclusive definition of Europe, and performers have pushed for either of two dialectical directions: expanding inclusiveness versus emphasizing ethnic and national identities. The EBU set the event with the specific aim of promoting common joyful experiences across national borders (Bourdon, 2007). As Tragaki (2013) suggested, ‘The Eurovision Song Contest (ESC) is more than a musical event that ostensibly “unites European people” through music. It is a spectacle and performative event, one that allegorically represents the idea of “Europe”’. Fricker and Gluhovic (2013) added that

The ESC, with its unique, imaginative, and aesthetic modality, has always been a symbolic contact zone between European cultures – an arena for European identification in which both national solidarity and participation in European identity are confirmed. It is also a site where cultural struggles over the meanings, frontiers, and limits of Europe, as well as similarities and differences existing within Europe, are enacted. (p. 3)

From the seven countries at the launch in 1956 to the more than 40 that take part today, the ESC celebrates the idea of a common European heritage – or, as some scholars suggest, an imagined and even fantasized utopia thereof (Anderson, 1983; Bohlman, 2007; Jones and Subotic, 2011) – namely, a liberal, cosmopolitan, universalist and peace-loving continent. According to Allatson (2007), rather than through those political ideals,

the ESC carves a common European identity through the use of Kitsch. In a recent paper on its political tensions, Jackson hailed the cosmopolitan function of the ESC:

The true phenomenon of Eurovision is that, despite political divides and culture clashes – as much as differences in music tastes – it has fostered European integration and togetherness. It is also relatively unique in giving the pan-European television audience the opportunity to simultaneously participate in being European and to determine an outcome, collectively, outside of nation state politics. And while the lingering political tensions will endure, this annual popular culture referendum continues to provide a space to belong – and that is clearly worth singing about.

The competitive setting of the ESC creates a seeming equality across the continent's nations – from small San Marino, Cyprus and Malta to giants like Germany, the United Kingdom, France, Spain and, more recently, Russia (Kyriakidou et al., 2017). But as Akin (2013) asserts, peripheral countries feel they are 'competing in a car race with a motor-bike' (p. 2314), an experience nowadays oddly shared by past Eurovision empires like Ireland and the United Kingdom that in the last decade got used to receiving *nil points* (Georgiou, 2008). Nevertheless, the ESC is one of the main cultural means for promulgating an imagined common heritage with people across countries – notwithstanding cultural, religious and political diversity – sharing a common cultural event. Furthermore, Raykoff and Tobin (2007) argued that the 'Eurovision Song Contest provides literal and figurative access [to the ideal of post-war Europe]: A society that is democratic, capitalist, peace-loving, multicultural, sexually liberated and technologically advanced' (p. xviii).

When core EU countries speak of Europe, they often refer to its liberal, peaceful, enlightened and democratic values, contrasting it with Eastern barbarism, savagery and homophobia (Jones and Subotic, 2011). When countries deviate from those peaceful and liberal values – for example, by declaring war on Iraq – they are rewarded with minimal votes or loud protests before and during the event. This was exemplified with protests against Russia in 2016. In spite of consistent predictions for a Russian victory (Eurovision World website), the favourite performer was 'punished' by voters who elected the Ukraine as the winner (with the song '1944', which focused on Soviet deportation of the Tatars from the Ukraine during World War II). On the other hand, when peripheral states uphold peace and liberal values, they may end up as winners of the contest – for example, Turkey winning the 2003 contest after barring Western aeroplanes from attacking Iraq using Turkish airfields – expanding the reach of Europeaness to Moslem states (Christensen and Christensen, 2008). In that sense, the ESC is a 'cosmopolitan empire', with post-Soviet states striving to perform claims to belonging and partnership and therefore perform acceptable identities from a Western point of view (Sieg, 2013b).

However, the ESC is mired in contradictions between 'political factors and apolitical ideals' (Raykoff, 2007: 3) or between unity and diversity. In the midst of the aforementioned pressures towards cosmopolitanism, a new line of research on 'nation branding' shows that the ESC is also a context for projecting idiosyncratic national and cultural identities (Arntsen, 2005; Baker, 2008; Danero Iglesias, 2015; Ismayilov, 2012; Jones and Subotic, 2011; Miazhevich, 2010, 2012; Mitrović, 2010). As Europe extends its borders, new states invest resources in order to present and advance their touristic and economic

interests through an emphasis of their 'ethnic' or traditional identities. Spain, for example, often performs *Flamenco* songs; the Greeks have played with *Rembetikos*. Repeated failures of local musical genres have not discouraged other nations to pursue particularistic beats and voices. In 2013, for example, Croatia elected the band 'Klapa s Mora' with the song *Mižerja* to represent its Klapa ethnic tradition. Indeed, studies have shown that national broadcasting associations use the Eurovision as 'a showcase of the host nation presented to the international audience' (Arntsen, 2005: 147). As Kavanagh (2010) adds,

for new entrants and indeed new states, such as the former Yugoslav and Soviet states, taking part in Eurovision was a means of staking a place on the European stage and furthering the process of 'becoming European', as well as viewing the contest as a means to furthering their country's economic development.

Indeed, post-Soviet countries – Estonia and Ukraine, for example – used the ESC for connecting with Western Europe and its modernist liberal project, seeking greater involvement with the EU. This was also the case for Latvia, Estonia and Norway (Arntsen, 2005). In most events, indeed, host countries signal that they endorse integration in the European community, opting for 'cosmopolitan hybridity rather than a conscious authenticity' (Bohlman, 2007: 46). Despite its Western orientation, added Bohlman (2007), the ESC reveals 'a changing and diverse Europe, where many rather than few musical identities have become a reality' (p. 65). Azerbaijan – which hosted the event in 2012 – opened the final stage with Moslem ethnic prayer, claiming that this too is Europe or European culture.

Notwithstanding its cosmopolitan orientation, Bolin (2010) indeed argued that the ESC is predicated on two contradictory agendas. As he said, 'There are (at least) two basic values at play in relation to the ESC: on the one hand, the idea of the nation state and, on the other, the value of Europeanness' (p. 131). This tension stands at the basis of national bias, cultural camps and even overt political pressures – leading Bolin to suggest that 'the event can be analyzed as both integrative and conflictual simultaneously' (Bolin, 2010). In addition, the ESC breeds and regenerates stereotypes relating to other nations – which reflect 'xenophobic, irrational bias' – thereby making the contest an arena for inter-nation projections and fantasies (Georgiou, 2008). In some cases, the ESC even generated protest campaigns against its implicit colonial orientation (namely, imposing Western ideals of cosmopolitanism, liberalism and universality).

The dualism between nation and continent led some scholars to suggest that host countries use the ESC in order to present a European identity for global spectators, while retaining a national and even regressive one for spectators on the home front. As Jones and Subotic (2011) argued, 'This is what performing Europeanization is: a desperate plea to belong and participate in the European idea, but without changing who we truly are' (p. 551). But true to its dualism, and although the EBU bans the use of politics in the contest, nationality and nationalism often loom large. According to Bohlman (2007), the ESC is not sheer entertainment, indeed: 'National song participates in the making of history, mobilizing historical agents and actors through performance, and gathering its diverse parts to realize the full panorama of past, present, and utopian future' (p. 57).

Given those tensions, it is evident that the ESC exposes rifts in Europe while celebrating its imagined unity. Johnson (2014) emphasized this fact in quoting a critique explaining the Russian disappointment after the 2009 Eurovision. The Russians, said Troitskii, ‘did not recognize that Eurovision was not the Slavic Bazaar music festival, that in this competition the accent is on the “euro” and that those same euro-values differ decisively from our Russian values’ (quoted in Johnson, 2014: 37). Such ambivalence leads to the manipulation of the contest through ‘big politics’. As a BBC Panorama documentary has recently exposed, the EBU hasn’t fully accustomed itself to political manipulations of the Eurovision exerted by some regimes, notably during the 2012 event in Azerbaijan (Lawson, 2012). The dualism is also apparent in debates about language use – English being the language that is most likely to be voted for in the contest – yet some countries insist on performing in their original language (notably France, Italy and Spain). Some participants seek to bridge languages, as did the Slovenian, Israeli and Polish performers in 2014, mixing English with their national language in order to appeal to both local and global audiences. The research, however, suggests that English is the lingua franca as it awards performers with a few extra points in the contest (see estimates in Clerides and Stengos, 2012).

An interesting theoretical development was recently proposed by Fricker and Gluhovic (2013), arguing that the ESC is a good example for Eisenstadt’s (2001) theory of multiple modernity. Revising the theory of a linear progression of all countries towards one modern model, Eisenstadt suggested that there are various ways to be modern. The ESC indeed celebrates the idea of multiplicity and multiculturalism. Turkish, Azerbaijani and Israeli performers – often seeming non-European – have won the contest and thereby extended the idea of Europe and its multicultural vision. Indeed, theoretical insertions like the idea of multiple modernity – like the concept of banal nationalism (Billig, 1995; Kyriakidou et al., 2017) – are likely to advance the academic standing of Eurovision studies.

Queering the ESC: gender transgressions and liberalism

One of the fascinating elements in the ESC – creating the phenomenon of Eurovision fandom (Highfield et al., 2013) – is the ritualistic bonding it creates in families (Singleton et al., 2007). Families turn the ESC into a festival: preparing special food for the occasion, laughing at singers and performances, conducting memory contests and betting on results, expressing hilarious disdain for some nations and, overall, performing a home-brewed celebration of national and European identity (Sandvoss, 2008). This family orientation of the ESC was intentioned by the EBU and has given room for the study of fans and fandom around the event (Singleton et al., 2007). Indeed, prior to multi-channel television, the Eurovision constituted a national and continental campfire for families and fans. With more than 30 percent of ratings in recent years, it has remained the most popular European campfire (Laufer, 2016).

A growing number of papers have exposed the various faces of Eurovision fandom and the alternative ‘families’ that use the Eurovision in celebrations of cross-national ‘camp’ identities. Lemish, a pioneering Israeli scholar of the ESC, was the first to expose how gay men use the Eurovision in carving an identity and space for relationships. She suggested that until Dana International’s victory in 1998, the identification of gays with

the contest was untapped by most viewers: 'It is as if the mainstream culture is blind to an undercurrent cultural existence, so dominant in the lives of a subordinated community' (Lemish, 2004: 46). Her study provided 'Ample evidence about Internet fan clubs, chat lines, visits abroad, personal acquaintances and the like – [which constitute] an international gay bond surrounding the ESC' (Lemish, 2004).

Following Lemish, a burgeoning body of scholarship focuses on queer identities and exposed features of gay parade in the ESC. Awareness of gay camp was brought into the open by Israeli performer Dana International, an expressive transsexual who won the 1998 contest. As Singleton et al. (2007) say, 'Dana International's performance pointed out, to the point of excess, the constructedness of gender. And from that point on, the secret was out: Eurovision had been queered' (p. 19). Dana's queering of the ESC has since then resurfaced in appearances by Marija Šerifović, Serbia in 2007, the drag queen performance of Verka Serduchka for the Ukraine in 2007 (Miazhevich, 2012) and Conchita Wurst from Austria who won the 2014 contest (Baker, 2017). Such public performances celebrate queer approaches to gender and feminism, while suggesting that gender and sexuality are constructed, vary over a continuum and are potentially chosen.

Studies of the transgressive nature of the ESC have focused on various aspects of the contest (see also three chapters in Fricker and Gluhovic, 2013). Motschenbacher (2013) exposed various features of non-heteronormative and same-sex intimations in the press conferences that precede the contest. Heller (2007) focused on the Russian entry to the 2003 contest with the duo t.A.T.u. – who seemed to challenge the Russian conservative and anti-gay culture (for another exegesis on Russia's manipulation of sexual identities in the ESC, see Miazhevich, 2010). Heller discussed the manners by which the duo presented themselves to their Russian audience and contrasted this identity with that presented to Western, more liberal audiences. She suggested that 't.A.T.u.'s reception in Russia reflects a greater openness to bisexuality, homosexuality, and sexual experimentation, an openness that has increasingly come to characterise the sexual attitudes of younger Russians, and young, urban Russian women in particular' (pp. 207–208). Cassidy added that the Russian play with homosexuality was its way to win the Eurovision in 2008, adding that Russia's manipulation of Western sexual values (Miazhevich, 2010) came to a halt in 2009 in re-embracing traditional homophobic values (Cassiday, 2014), which has led to protests in the following years.

The optimism that several observers had in interpreting post-Soviet uses of alternative sexualities is toned down by Vänskä (2007). Superficially, she said, the victory of the lesbian singer Šerifović with Molitva in the 2007 contest made it 'apparent that this was not just the victory of Serbia, but it was the victory of the Roma and lesbians – and thereby of the utopia of tolerance' (p. 67). But that victory, she added, was a bit of wishful thinking, as 'sexual rights are not in the same level in former Soviet countries like they are in Western European countries' (p. 72). This critical take resurfaced in studies by Gluhovic (2013) and Sieg (2013a). Nevertheless, the sexual vision of the Eurovision is clear, celebrating lesbian, gay, bisexual and transgender (LGBT) identities as the new mode of modernity. Although the EBU bans politics, transgender performers, drag queens, homosexuals and lesbians constitute the liberal spearheads of the cosmopolitan vision of the ESC. They symbolize that Europe stands for liberal and humanitarian ideals

while furthering the understanding of the constructedness of gender and sexuality. As this strand of research shows, 'gay fandom' and 'camp aesthetic' have become part of mainstream European culture, and the ESC celebrates those liberal values, necessitating participants to decide whether they are 'in or out'. The recent decision by Turkey to abort its participation – responding to the victory of Conchita Wurst in 2014 – provides a good example for the debate over gender, religion, tradition and Europeanness.

Euro-Divisions: bloc voting versus song quality in the ESC

The ESC winner is decided by a country-to-country vote, with 1 to 8 points, 10 points and 12 points (Douze Point); thus, each participating country can 'favour' 10 out of 40 other countries (participants cannot vote for their own performance). The common assumption is that the best song wins. However, many studies have exposed political alliances and 'bloc voting' in the contest. The first academic studies to point out 'bloc voting' were published in the 1990s (Yair, 1995; Yair and Maman, 1996). The authors identified a division into three blocs: the Nordic bloc, the Western bloc and the Mediterranean bloc. They demonstrated that the size of the blocs and the rules of the competition led countries in smaller blocs (e.g. four in Scandinavian and six in the Mediterranean blocs, respectively) to 'export' their extra votes to the Western bloc. Indeed, given the cultural or linguistic distance between the Nordic bloc and the Mediterranean, countries in those blocs had to 'export' their surplus votes to West European countries, making performers from Ireland, France, Luxembourg, the UK and Switzerland the beneficiaries of this persistent structure. At the time of those early publications, non-Western performers won the ESC only in outstanding cases (e.g. ABBA for Sweden in 1974), leading to the conclusion that the quest for a fair vote in the ESC, one based on the quality of performance, is challenged by Europe's cultural and political divisions.

Voting patterns in the ESC and the suspicion that the contest is unfair encouraged many scholars to revisit those initial results, which predated the inclusion of post-Soviet countries in the ESC. Scholars differ in the period they choose to model the data; they also employ different statistical methods – network methods, q-methods and various other highly sophisticated developments in estimations of ranking data. Irrespective of period or method, however, the results always expose underlying cultural and political voting patterns, which expose a divided – rather than a unified – continent. The 'Bloc' hypothesis, in other words, is repeatedly confirmed.

In one of the very first reproductions of the bloc hypothesis, Gatherer (2003) used data from 1974 to 2002 to point to the rise of coalitions (Greece and Cyprus or Sweden and Denmark, for example). He exposed similar blocs to those identified in prior studies, but with data for post-Soviet participation, he identified five blocs that he creatively titled as follows: the Viking Empire, the Warsaw Pact, the Maltese Cross, the Cyprus Triad and the Axis of Britain (Gatherer, 2003). As Gatherer again confirmed for data spanning 30 years (1975–2005), 'On at least two occasions, the outcome of the contest has been crucially affected by voting blocs. The structure of these blocs implies that a handful of centrally placed countries have a higher probability of being future winners' (Gatherer, 2006).

In a paper titled 'How Does Europe Make Its Mind Up?', a group of researchers applied network methods to voting results from 1992 to 2003 and confirmed that 'voting

cliques exist' (Fenn et al., 2006). In a following study of voting from 1984 to 2003, Saavedra et al. (2007) attempted to find a global pattern for identifying the winning song (with 60% of the countries voting at least one of the highest five ranks), finding evidence for bloc voting once more.

Scholars often debate the logic of voting preferences. Concern is for the meritocratic principle of 'song quality', seeking to differentiate it from collusive voting based on linguistic, cultural, geographic or political factors. Two mathematicians used data from 1975 to 2003 to show that political voting is apparent (Spierdijk and Vellekoop, 2006: 19). Ginsburgh and Noury also attempted to disprove the bloc thesis but had to concur. They used regression methods to predict voting results using data from the same years (Ginsburgh and Noury, 2008: 49). The conclusions of both papers are similar:

We find that geographical factors substantially affect the voting behaviour in the Eurovision Song Contest. Even after correction for cultural, linguistic and other factors, many countries prefer or dislike the songs of neighbouring countries or other countries close by. This gives rise to the suspicion that the geographical effects reflect 'political' voting, as it is difficult to think of any other reasons why countries would adopt such behavior. (Spierdijk and Vellekoop, 2006: 19)

All our results point in the same direction: 'Quality' is the main determinant in the voting procedure, linguistic and other cultural factors are present, but not at the forefront. Political vote trading is not an issue once cultural factors are taken into account. This does not mean that there is no vote trading, but it is rather due to cultural and linguistic factors. (Ginsburgh and Noury, 2008: 49)

Applying newly developed network methods to the results of the 2005 event, Dekker argued that notwithstanding song quality, the number of borders separating two countries predicts voting patterns – again supporting the bloc hypothesis (Dekker, 2007). As he said, 'Our analysis of the Eurovision Song Contest data reveals a set of friendship blocs, and a significant tendency to vote for nearby countries' (p. 54). Specifically, his results from 2005 also evidenced five blocs: East European, Nordic, Baltic, Eastern Mediterranean and Western blocs. The persistent pattern persists.

In a recent and highly sophisticated paper on multidimensional ranking data, Jacques and Biernacki (2014) also reproduced the bloc hypothesis in pointing towards the 'existence of geographical voting alliances' (p. 13). Given their focus on recent data (2007–2012), they reproduced the classic three blocs – Western, Nordic and Mediterranean – and confirmed the rise of a new political and cultural alliance, namely, East Europe.

The past decade had witnessed the 'taking over' of the ESC by peripheral countries, some of which are hardly identified with Western European ideals. The inclusive approach of the EBU turned the Western dominance of earlier periods on its head. As Bohlman (2007) argued,

The centripetal pull of the Eurovision's ideology of drawing East and West, North and South, together toward a common aesthetic ideal had given way to the centrifugal force generated along the peripheries of expanding participation, above all in the East, with its growing contingency of participants from the former Soviet Union. (p. 40)

The expansion of the contest's borders brought in particularistic or localized national musical genres, exposing European cultural heterogeneity and political affiliations. Those political and geographical cleavages led past winners to express critiques about the 'kidnapping' of the contest. They prompted Kavanagh (2010), for example, to devote long deliberations on political voting patterns which explained, he suggested, the decline of the Celtic Tiger in the ESC.

A new approach for the study of bloc voting was recently published by Nicholas Charron, a business professor from Copenhagen University. In one of the most statistically sophisticated and theoretically driven papers ever published on the ESC, Charron attempted to decompose quality of song from friendship commitments – a la Dekker (2007). However, having interest in political corruption, Charron innovated by including data on national political features. He was thus able to decompose voting variance in the ESC by levels of political impartiality. Using data from 1998 to 2012, Charron (2013) concluded that democratic or impartial countries are more sensitive to song quality than countries with lesser democratic traditions that more visibly opt to adopt bloc voting and local alliances. Loyalty – which is contra-posed to song quality and voting fairness – is found to decline as impartiality levels rise. His results suggest that as the EBU expanded its inclusive orientation to non-democratic regimes, it has allowed even more collusive voting patterns to possibly corrupt quality and fairness at the ESC.

Some studies in the bloc tradition took a more technical route in assessing the effects of the contest's format. One study focused on the order of the songs in the contest, exposing the advantages accrued for being positioned at the end of the contest (De Bruin, 2005). Other scholars sought to assess the effects of traditional 'aristocratic' voting patterns against the new rules adopted by the EBU, namely, its decision to adopt more popular and democratic 'televoting' procedures. This technique was first implemented in 1998. To study the effects of the change, Orgaz et al. (2011) conducted a comparative investigation of results obtained under jury voting (1992–1996) versus results obtained by televoting methods (2004–2008). To test the effects of the change, they used sophisticated Clique Percolation Methods (CPM) for community detection and the Edge Betweenness and Community (EBC) structure algorithm. Their results exposed the persistence of bloc structures or communities of states that are biased to vote inside blocs. But they also found that televoting increased alignments across local borders and strengthened the effect of diaspora communities (e.g. Turkish immigrants in Western Europe voting for Turkey). They concluded that televoting created 'a much more fragmented Eurovision, both geographically and culturally, while disrupting the reign of past classical winners' (i.e. Ireland). Dekker (2007) reported similar results from his network modelling of the 2005 contest. Following growing critiques of televoting leading to bloc voting, the EBU combined the two methods, allowing the Nordic bloc to recoup since 2009.

The Eurovision as a cultural seismograph

Looked at carefully, academic studies of the ESC provide important vehicles for understanding current political visions and divisions across Europe – West and East, North and South, Soviet and post-Soviet. As several researchers suggest, indeed, Eurovision data and the methods applied in its analysis might have general applications for understanding European politics and economic relations. As Fenn et al. (2006) suggested, 'The

Eurovision network is analogous to a range of other complex dynamical networks involving the exchange of goods or opinions'. Dekker (2007) added that the 'Contest results do indeed provide a window into European politics' (p. 53). The evidence suggests that the ESC often hides deep cultural traumas and national animosities (e.g. the Ukrainian winning song of 2016, '1944', referring to the Soviet deportation of the Crimean Tatars). Azerbaijan and Armenia, Turkey and Greece, Russia and the former satellites, Romania and Moldova, these are some examples for the rifts that disrupt the Eurovision fantasy of the brotherhood of nations. Consequently, close attention to songs, lyrics, media interpretations and voting patterns provides a useful seismograph for exposing deep national traumas and cultural conflicts. In this context, it is apt to reference Bohlman (2007) once more, as he suggests that

The Eurovision Song Contest, however camp and jouissance, minority and majority politics compete for and on the mainstage, allows us to chart the roads that diverge and intersect on the landscapes of a Europe that has the potential to collapse into fragments or cohere with a new wholeness. As a site of power, pleasure, and prayer, the Eurovision Song Contest also becomes the site of politics, utopian and dystopian. (p. 66)

Specifically, if we want to understand current tensions between Russia and the Ukraine, for example, we should take a close look at the ESC (Raykoff, 2007). This was made evident by Ukraine's 2004 winner Ruslana, who recently declared that 'Russia is our past, Europe must be our future' (reported by Reuters, 12 December 2013), or by Jamala's 2016 performance with the anti-Russian song '1944'. But signs for the Russian-Ukrainian rift were detected by scholars even before the eruption of the 2014 conflict. As Miazhevich (2012) suggested,

The Ukrainian entry by Verka Serdutchka in 2007, as well as online responses to the show, aimed to articulate a vision of European nationhood, which simultaneously staked a position among other states of the former Soviet Union and reconfigured relationships with the shared Soviet past. (p. 1505)

Serdutchka's performance opted to present the Ukraine in the guise of 'progressive modernity' while distancing itself from its Soviet past. Furthermore, a recent paper by Emily Johnson focused on the tension which erupted between Russia and the Ukraine around the 2009 Russian entry 'Mamo' – performed by the Ukrainian singer Prikhod'ko. The debates around the event, suggested Johnson, seemed a premonition of the current crisis between the former members of the Soviet Union. As Johnson (2014) said,

Given the controversy that erupted over Prikhod'ko's nomination and the tensions that divided Russia, Ukraine, and Georgia in spring 2009, less than a year after the Russo-Georgian War over South Ossetia and Abkhazia, the presence of these nostalgic elements in 'Mamo' inevitably seemed politically freighted: the song effectively juxtaposed Soviet-style 'ethnic harmony' to the quarrels of the present and hence, depending on one's point of view, either read as a touching appeal for peace and tolerance or as a veiled threat that hinted at the possible renewal of Russia's cultural dominance over the other former Soviet republics ... The fact that 'Mamo'

evoked both Soviet rhetoric and the USSR's old borders might reasonably be read as a veiled threat – in the context of post-Soviet politics it can be difficult to tell a desire for unity and closer cooperation from aggressive expansionism. (p. 43)

Johnson's brilliant analysis provides one example for this broader message: the ESC holds keys for understanding political and economic relations between European countries – in dyads or in larger bloc formations. Her exegesis of the Russia–Ukraine conflict was corroborated by a recent paper by Akin (2013), who reported that during the event in Istanbul in 2004, an odd but culturally understandable exchange took place. One of his senior interviewees told him, 'The national spokesperson for [*sic*] Cyprus jury, while giving the votes from Nicosia, said "Good evening Constantinople!"' As a response, our presenter replied, 'Good evening Greek part of Cyprus!' The spokesperson in response said, 'This is not the Greek part of Cyprus, this is Cyprus!' And our presenter replied, 'This is Istanbul for the last 600 years, not Constantinople. Still could not you learn?' He also noted that Turkey blocked the airing of the Greek song in 1976, an event that recurred during the broadcast of the Armenian song by Azerbaijan a few years ago. Countries hold grudges for decades, and the ESC is one seismograph for detecting them. Gatherer (2006) tended to take a light approach to the competition, but the above-mentioned references remind us of his less optimistic option, namely, that if one looks at ESC in the context of an expanded EU, one could also find evidence for grim inter-regional struggles. Should we indeed seek better testimonies for the persistence of cultural rivalries? And should we be surprised when such animosities turn into geo-political conflicts?

Furthermore, several scholars have found that voting patterns in the Eurovision help explaining international trade relations, extending the use of Eurovision data in economic theory. The first study to do so suggested that 'The central conclusion of our paper is that cultural proximity is a more important determinant of bilateral trade than researchers usually allow with the sort of cultural variables they include' (Felbermayr and Toubal, 2010: 280). They also pointed that 'ESC scores indeed reflect cultural proximity' and that 'proximity is a major determinant of bilateral trade volumes' (Felbermayr and Toubal, 2010: 291). In a recent paper published by business professors from Copenhagen University, Kokko and Tingvall (2014) argue that 'The choice of export destinations and locations for foreign direct investment is not determined by objective economic data alone but also by how familiar the exporter or investor is with the target market'. To capture the effects of international 'familiarity' on trade patterns, they use the idea of 'psychic distance' or cultural homology and add them to traditional economic variables like distance, preferences and price. Since cultural affinities predict Eurovision voting patterns, they argue that the 'results of the European Song Contest are a robust predictor of bilateral trade' (Kokko and Tingvall, 2014). This implies, they suggest, that 'A stronger preference for country *i* in country *j*'s ESC votes suggests that country *j* will also import more goods from country *i*, controlling for other determinants of trade'. They also suggest that ESC data became better predictors with the move to popular televoting – as publics are more relevant to economic consumption than expert juries. As Tanase and García have recently added, Eurovision results are sensitive to economic conditions. They argue that the monetary crisis in Europe has widened the gap between countries and blocs. As they said, 'The polarization in the Eurovision would be an early indicator

for a social and cultural phenomenon, which is followed by states of distrust in the economy of the involved countries' (Tanase and García, 2013: 28). Recent Greek performances, for example, provided clear testimonies for the German–Greek conflict – either self-critique at Greek character or economic conditions, or against external monetary control of Greece by Germany. Overall, it seems that economic crises affect cultural distance between countries, and this growing distance can be observed through voting patterns. The ESC, in this sense, is indeed a political and economic seismograph.

Conclusion: holes in the new enlightenment

In many ways, the ESC provides a cultural rendition for the European Enlightenment tradition. Indeed, the Swedish organizing team arranged a performance titled 'We Write the Story' for the opening ceremony of the 2013 ESC final, staged in Sweden's Malmö Arena. The lyrics of the anthem conveyed the European Enlightenment ideals in the clearest form possible: 'Justice and peace and liberty, We write the story, We can fulfil the legacy, We write the song, Welcome a new enlightenment, We write the story'.

The EBU attempted to bring this Enlightenment's vision into a reality. Clearly post-WWII trauma made it ever more urgent to create 'perpetual peace'. But since critical reflection should be wary of political correctness, scholars should differentiate between the utopian agenda – which is best represented by the anthem of the Eurovision (Tragaki, 2013) – and the actual cultural and national differences which separate Europe. Two decades of serious study of the Eurovision has exposed that the ideological ideal of unity is persistently challenged by national and primordial commitments. Indeed, the research accumulated over the past two decades exposed the betrayal of the EBU's Kantian ideal of the solidarity of nations. Therefore, rather than believing the televised utopia of a common humanity, the serious body of scholarship on the ESC provides a necessary seismograph for revealing deeply rooted cultural traumas and national humiliations that under what seems to be ephemeral aspirations of political unity. As the present review suggests, indeed, what many deem to be a silly show of musical mediocrity actually proves to be a productive area for the serious study of European civilization and its discontents.

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